

Caramelized Sweet potato with toasted pumpkin seeds

This colorful side dish makes a beautiful presentation. It's especially appropriate in the fall and winter months, and, of course, is perfect for the holiday table. I find a well-seasoned cast-iron skillet works best here, but a nonstick skillet will do.

2 medium beets, scrubbed and cut into $\frac{3}{8}$ -inch [1-cm] dice

1 medium sweet potato, scrubbed and cut into $\frac{3}{8}$ -inch [1-cm] dice

3 tablespoons fresh pumpkin seeds

$\frac{1}{2}$ pound green beans, stem ends and strings removed [250g]

1 tablespoon plus 2 teaspoons olive oil

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. Set the beets on one half of a steamer rack and steam for about 10 minutes, until they begin to soften slightly. **Arrange** the sweet potato on the other half of the rack. A few overlaps are okay, but the key is try to keep the vegetables as separate as possible so the beets don't bleed all over the sweet potato. Continue to steam until both vegetables are tender.
2. While the sweet potato and beets are cooking, place the pumpkin seeds in a large dry skillet, preferably cast-iron, over medium-high heat. **Shake** the pan or stir frequently until most of the seeds have popped, about 30 seconds. Immediately remove from the pan and set aside.
3. In the same skillet, **sauté** the green beans in 2 teaspoons of the olive oil for 2 to 3 minutes, stirring and tossing frequently, until softened but still slightly crunchy. You may choose to brown them slightly for extra flavor. Set the beans aside in the middle of a round platter.
4. **Spoon** the cooked beets around the beans. In the same skillet, sauté the steamed

sweet potato in the remaining 1 tablespoon oil over high heat, tossing, until lightly browned, about 2 minutes.

5. Spoon the sweet potatoes on top of the beets. **Drizzle** the lemon juice over the vegetables and season with salt and pepper to taste. Sprinkle the toasted pumpkin seeds over all.

SERVES 4

Asian-inspired sugar snap peas and red peppers

Bright-green sugar snap peas, so **tender** they are eaten pod and all, along with scarlet bell peppers make a striking pair. The combination is versatile enough to accompany a wide range of other dishes. Serve with Citrus-Marinated Tofu Cutlets (page 122) and Cauliflower Puree (page 261).

1 large red bell pepper, cut into 1-inch [2.5-cm] strips

2 teaspoons olive oil

8 ounces fresh sugar snap peas, stemmed, strings removed [250g]*

2 teaspoons toasted sesame oil

2 teaspoons soy sauce

½ teaspoon sugar

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1. In a large nonstick skillet, **sauté** the bell pepper strips in the olive oil over medium-high heat until bright red and just slightly softened, about 2 minutes.
2. Add the sugar snap peas and cook, **tossing**, until they are crisp-tender and bright green, 1 to 2 minutes longer.
3. Add the sesame oil, soy sauce, and sugar and remove from the heat. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste. Toss and serve at once.

SERVES 4

*Substitute snow peas if sugar snaps are not available.